

1 The basics

1.1 What is hacking?

Hacking is often portrayed to be many things it is not. Thanks to the popular portrayal of hackers as young immoral computer experts associated with nearly any possible illegal and immoral activity that can be conducted through a computer, we see hackers are outlaws of cyberspace, out to steal passwords, or get access to your bank account and steal money. They are portrayed as the equivalent to thieves who break into houses or rob banks – or in the mildest case, peeping toms trying to get a look into your private life.

This could not be farther from the truth. Sure, the act of remotely accessing someone's computer to steal their private files would be hacking. Note the words “steal their private files”, what if that condition was removed? Or what if you are simply accessing your own computer or that of a friend's to help him / her out?

Much like the driver of a car would be called a driver, whether it is done by someone with the car owner's permission, by the car owner himself / herself or without the car owner's permission. Driving is driving regardless of the ethics; the context is irrelevant. Similarly a person is a hacker whether they are bypassing their own computer's security to access their own files, or doing it on someone else's computer without the permission of the owner.

A person withdrawing money from an ATM using their card is okay; a person withdrawing money from an ATM using someone else's card without their permission is a thief. A person hacking into a computer to test its security is a hacker who is a security expert, a person hacking into a computer to steal passwords is a criminal. Here the context decides the legality and ethics of the act, and the person is accordingly labelled a “security expert” or “criminal”, but he is a hacker nonetheless.

Hacking is an expression of our own curiosity, “how does it work?”, “why can't I access it?”, “what happens if I give it 400 volts instead of 220?” It is simply the result of our drive to understand the things around us. Often people are curious about things which may cause them or others harm, such as a child curious about an electricity socket, or an teen curious about drugs. This is no reason to discourage curiosity, the answer, as always, lies in education not restriction. Many of the greatest minds have simply been unsatisfied by the reality they see around them, and looked for ways to “hack” things to work in ways they want. Without their curiosity, and “hacking” skills, where would we have been?

A computer hacker is one who is curious about the working of computers and software. While many people are happy treating their computer like a black box, where they merely feed in data and get data in return, others